Security Act to freeze the UK assets of Landsbanki, and the assets of the Central Bank of Iceland and the Government of Iceland that related to Landsbanki. Although these laws were supposed to function in order to keep funds out of the hands of terrorists, they were being used against the government of another European power. It was shocking. There was a great deal of backroom diplomacy on the part of the British – real strong-arm stuff – and the instincts of empire really emerged in them. When it comes to such things, where there is a consuming public passion for the issue, as there is in the banking debacle, the British could use naked power to get their own way. And they did. They stated publicly that they would campaign against Iceland's entry into the EU unless they got their money and that they would leverage the IMF to refuse to give Iceland any loans. The Icelandic parliament attempted to draw up a repayment plan, but, under pressure from public opinion, the president refused to sign it through, triggering a public referendum under the Icelandic constitution. While some members of the Icelandic political establishment frantically tried to find a deal that would satisfy the British, we began to leak documents such as the UK–Netherlands' 'final offer' and the Icelandic counter-proposal. I also spoke at a rally in Reykjavik, and our efforts in general were devoted to providing the Icelandic public with the information they needed to make an informed decision. In the end, about 95 per cent of the voting population voted against succumbing to British pressure, a historic moment in Iceland as the country was experiencing its first referendum since 1944. Our ability to act strategically in the face of a dynamic story is part of our importance, forcing those in power to confront the truth at a point where events are developing. We eventually published several cables showing the UK had been lobbying an organisation called the Paris Club – a creditor cartel of the major Western creditor nations – to refuse to give Iceland any further assistance.

We would have some deep and final business with Iceland during 2010, but that momentous year of 2009 – the year we had hoped to found the world's first openness haven there – ended with a curious reminder of how much WikiLeaks had become woven into the fabric of Icelandic self-consciousness. There was a party at the US embassy in Reykjavik. They always invited the political elite to these parties, and I crashed it under the guise of being Birgitta's plus-one. (I was on my own: she didn't come at all.) I was feeling perky that night: I had managed to secure a series of